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GAMING



Itch.io is the latest
marketplace to crack
down on adult games

Indie video game marketplace [Itch.io](#) announced this week that it has [“deindexed” adult and not-safe-for-work games](#) removing them from its browse and search pages.

The move, the company said, was in response to a campaign by Collective Shout (an advocacy group that has [previously criticized](#) video games, rap music, and lingerie commercials) targeting both [Itch.io](#) and Steam for selling “No Mercy,” a game that [depicts rape and incest](#).

In an [open letter](#) addressed to executives at PayPal, Mastercard, Visa, and other payment processors, Collective Shout said that games “endorsing men’s sexualised abuse and torture of women and girls fly in the face of efforts to address violence against women.”

“We do not see how facilitating payment transactions and deriving financial benefit from these violent and unethical games, is consistent with your corporate values and mission statements,” the organization added.

The campaign appears to have worked, with Steam saying earlier this month that it would [ban games](#) that “may violate the rules and standards set forth by Steam’s payment processors and related card networks and banks, or internet network providers.”

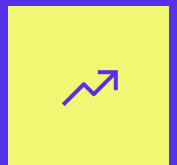
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Similarly, [Itch.io](#) said, “To ensure that we can continue to operate and provide a marketplace for all developers, we must prioritize our relationship with our payment partners and take immediate steps towards compliance.”

It also said that “No Mercy” had been “temporarily available on itch.io before being banned back in April,” and that “the situation developed rapidly,” forcing the company to “act urgently to protect the platform’s core payment infrastructure,” without providing advanced notice to creators.

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The company said it’s now conducting a “comprehensive audit” to ensure that games available on the marketplace meet “the requirements of our payment processors,” with adult content remaining deindexed until the audit is complete. After the audit, [Itch.io](#) said NSFW game creators will be required to confirm that their content is allowed under the policies of their payment processors linked to their account.

On social media, users criticizing [Itch.io](#)'s decision noted that its [current terms](#) declare that adult content violations are “permanent with no chance of appeal” and that any funds in an offending account “will not be eligible for payout” — or as one developer [put it](#), “If you violate the rules, we take all your money. Not just the money from that work, ALL your money from EVERYTHING you’ve ever made.”

This is far from the first time that payment companies appear to have pressured online platforms over adult content — for example, last year Gumroad pointed to restrictions from payment processors when it [implemented stricter rules](#) around NSFW art, and OnlyFans also blamed “banking partners and payment providers” when it [banned explicit content](#) (a decision that it [subsequently reversed](#)).

A [Change.org petition](#) with more than 137,000 verified signatures criticizes Mastercard and Visa for their role in these types of decisions. Among other things, the petition demands that the payment companies “stop censoring legal fictional content that complies with the law and platform standards” and “reject influence from activist groups that promote moral panic or misrepresent fiction as harm.”

Topics: [Commerce](#) [Gaming](#) [itch.io](#) [mastercard](#)

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Anthony Ha

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Anthony Ha is TechCrunch's weekend editor. Previously, he worked as a tech reporter at Adweek, a senior editor at...



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GAMING



Mastercard denies pressuring game platforms, Valve tells a different story

Anthony Ha — 2:29 PM PDT · August 3, 2025

The outcry after a recent marketplace crackdown on games with adult content, seemingly due to pressure from payment processors, prompted Mastercard to release [a brief statement](#) Friday pushing back against recent headlines.

“Mastercard has not evaluated any game or required restrictions of any activity on game creator sites and platforms, contrary to media

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reports and allegations,” the company said, adding, “At the same time, we require merchants to have appropriate controls to ensure Mastercard cards cannot be used for unlawful purchases, including illegal adult content.”

This follows [an open letter](#) by the advocacy group Collective Shout addressed to executives at PayPal, Mastercard, Visa, and other companies, criticizing them for allowing the sale of “No Mercy” and other games that depict rape, incest, and child sexual abuse.

In the following weeks, Steam announced that it would ban games that violate the rules of its “payment processors and related card networks and banks.” Then [Itch.io](#) said it was [removing games with adult content](#) from its browse and search pages while conducting a broader audit.

While Mastercard’s statement seems to undermine the narrative that payment and card companies were the ones pressuring the game marketplaces, Steam owner Valve responded with a statement of its own, [provided to PC Gamer](#) and other gaming sites.

According to Valve, “Mastercard did not communicate with Valve directly, despite our request to do so. Mastercard communicated with payment processors and their acquiring banks. Payment processors communicated this with Valve, and we replied by outlining Steam’s policy since 2018 of attempting to distribute games that are legal for distribution.”

Valve said its response was “rejected” by the payment processors, who noted the “risk to the Mastercard brand” and pointed to a Mastercard rule against “illegal or brand-damaging transactions.”

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Meanwhile, Itch.io said that it's now [re-indexing free games with adult content](#) while negotiating with payment processors, including Stripe, which for its part said it's "unable to support sexually explicit content" due to "banking partners."

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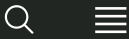


Anthony Ha

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Anthony Ha is TechCrunch's weekend editor. Previously, he worked as a tech reporter at Adweek, a senior editor at...

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payments

Sarah Perez — 7:12 AM PDT · September 6, 2016

PayPal this morning [announced](#) an expanded partnership with MasterCard aimed at helping the payments service become a more universally accepted checkout method at stores. The partnership, which follows a similar deal with Visa earlier this year, will make MasterCard a clear payment option within PayPal, increase PayPal’s presence at point-of-sale, and will enable

Masterpass (MasterCard's digital wallet) as a payment option for PayPal's Braintree merchants.

In July, PayPal buried the hatchet with [Visa](#) as well, in a deal that makes PayPal an option when people pay in stores with their smartphone. The partnership also helped PayPal's Venmo service, as its users could now instantly withdraw money when they linked their Venmo account to their Visa debit cards. MasterCard cardholders will now have a similar ability to make instant transfers on Venmo, via MasterCard Send.

With MasterCard now on board with PayPal, the goal is to help PayPal establish more traction at point-of-sale, where it's facing increased competition from tap-and-pay rivals like Apple Pay, and to a lesser extent, Android Pay and Samsung Pay. Some stores have also implemented their own digital payments service, like Starbucks, [Walmart](#), and [more recently, CVS](#).

PayPal says it will increase its presence at stores by allowing customers to use their tokenized MasterCard in their PayPal Wallet to make in-store purchases at more than 5 million merchants around the world where contactless payments are supported.

In addition, under the expanded partnership between PayPal and MasterCard, consumers and small businesses will be able to instantly cash out funds held in their PayPal account to a MasterCard account. PayPal will also receive certain financial volume incentives, as it did with Visa, and MasterCard will no longer charge PayPal the digital wallet operator fee.

Where before PayPal encouraged customers to link to their bank accounts as a means of routing around the large payment networks, like Visa and MasterCard, these new deals see PayPal treating

them equally to that option. PayPal will no longer encourage MasterCard cardholders to link their bank accounts, it says, and will now present MasterCard as a clear payment option in its Wallet, while also making it possible for consumers to set their MasterCard as their default payment method.

Masterpass will also be made a payment option for those merchants who process payments via Braintree, a PayPal-owned company. This will let merchants integrate Masterpass into their checkout experience more easily. (Thanks to the earlier deal with Visa, Visa Checkout was separately announced today as also coming to Braintree.)



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The two companies expanded a prior relationship, too, by agreeing to a multi-year extension of the PayPal Business Debit MasterCard program in the U.S., which follows a deal to extend the PayPal Extras MasterCard co-branded credit card program.

While an important strategic move for PayPal in terms of increasing its payments service at point-of-sale and online, where it faces newer rivals like Stripe, making deals with Visa and MasterCard could also impact PayPal's profits in the short-terms. Bank transfers are free, but working with the payment networks means PayPal will be paying fees. These concerns [caused PayPal's stock](#) to drop when the Visa deal was announced, but as of this morning the stock was [on the rise](#).

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Credit card and
payments companies

compete for a slice of the growing BNPL market

Ryan Lawler, Mary Ann Azevedo

10:25 AM PDT · October 28, 2021



Buy now, pay later is here to stay.

A year ago, the biggest players in the space were companies founded solely to offer consumers the ability to pay in installments at the point of sale. Sweden's Klarna, Australia's Afterpay and U.S.-based Affirm were the top names associated with BNPL.

But the landscape looks very different now that more companies recognize the opportunity and fight for a piece of the pie. PayPal last month spent \$2.7 billion for Japan's Paidy in an effort [to crack the market in Asia](#). In early August, Square announced [plans to acquire Afterpay](#) in a \$29 billion deal. Even [Apple is said to be getting into the BNPL game](#).

Today's BNPL space is seeing a slow emergence of a symbiotic relationship between traditional financial institutions, payments upstarts and leading companies. As credit card and payments firms eye BNPL as a new growth opportunity, incumbents like Klarna and Affirm are seeking ways to make their installment loans available to more consumers.

The bigwigs enter the fray

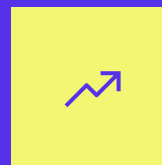
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Now that consumers are growing comfortable with BNPL services, the big credit card providers are taking steps to ensure they aren't left behind. Visa said on Wednesday that a "growing list" of issuers, acquirers and fintechs are using its technology to offer BNPL options to their customers.

In a statement, Mary Kay Bowman, Visa's SVP and global head of payment and platform products, said the company has been "enthusiastically embracing BNPL" for years "because it expands choice and convenience for buyers and sellers alike."

"If shoppers prefer a BNPL fintech solution, we are here and enabling it," she said. "If they want an option from their banks, we're helping offer those too." Interestingly, Visa said today it has inked a "global brand deal" with BNPL giant Klarna to accelerate its expansion and scale in several markets.

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The news comes a month after Mastercard announced its own BNPL offering: [Mastercard](#)

[Installments](#). Mastercard's chief product officer Craig Vosburg said at the time: "At the heart of it, payments come down to choice — and people want more from their money with greater flexibility and control in how they pay and where they shop." The company said the move was driven by both merchant and consumer demand.

It's not really a surprise that these credit card companies are stepping it up when it comes to BNPL. If anything, it's a wonder that it took them this long. More customers choosing to pay in installments means less interchange revenue for the likes of Visa and Mastercard. It only makes sense that they have found a way to make sure they're not left out.

But despite its growing popularity, some argue that BNPL is just another form of debt and can be detrimental to people who are already struggling financially.

Payments providers embracing BNPL

The big credit card companies aren't the only ones seeking to be a part of the BNPL land grab. Smaller payments companies like Stripe and Marqeta are also getting in on the action by making BNPL a part of their API offerings.

Earlier this week, Stripe said it was [working with Klarna](#) to let its customers offer installment options at the point of sale. According to the [announcement](#), the partnership will give customers in 20 countries access to BNPL services and will also make Stripe the preferred payment partner for Klarna in the U.S. and Canada.

This isn't Stripe's first BNPL partnership: Stripe [partnered with Afterpay](#) to integrate its payment

service into their checkout flow in February. But the deal was announced before Afterpay was acquired by Square, so Stripe's partnership with Klarna could be a hedge against losing BNPL access owned by the competition.

While Stripe is partnering with some of the big players in the BNPL space, card issuer and payments platform Marqeta is taking a different approach. It announced a [partnership with BNPL provider Zip](#), which helped the Australia-based company increase conversions through the use of virtual cards.

Marqeta also [struck a deal](#) with bank tech provider [Amount](#) that is designed to expand the availability of virtual cards and BNPL solutions through more traditional financial institutions. By offering BNPL in more places, these payment companies hope to get a small cut of the burgeoning market.

BNPL companies jockey for distribution

While credit card and payment providers are trying to get in on the market, how the big BNPL players are positioning themselves can help us understand where the space is going. As the market continues to grow, Klarna, Affirm and Afterpay are each establishing their own lanes in the hunt for greater distribution.

Afterpay, which already has a strong presence at brick-and-mortar retailers' checkout counters, was a perfect acquisition partner for Square and its network of point-of-sale merchants. By teaming up, the companies will have BNPL opportunities with more Square merchants, while also giving Afterpay a broader distribution network.

At the same time, Affirm has gone whale hunting. The company's partnerships with companies like [Amazon](#), [Shopify](#) and [American Airlines](#) allows it to increase volume by simply being available as an option during online checkouts, which millions of end users use every day.

Klarna, meanwhile, is seeking to expand its reach through a series of partnerships with card issuers and payments providers that will help it embed BNPL into the long tail of online merchants. By striking deals with companies like Visa and Stripe, it is counting on fintechs and developers to drive its growth over time.

It's unlikely that BNPL is a winner-take-all — or even a winner-take-most — market. It seems different options will be available in different contexts, whether a consumer is making a transaction at an offline merchant, through a global e-commerce behemoth, or at one of the tens of thousands of independent checkout pages powered by Stripe.

And just as Klarna, Affirm and the like will continue to find new ways to get in front of more customers, e-commerce and payments companies will pursue BNPL as a way to expand their businesses.

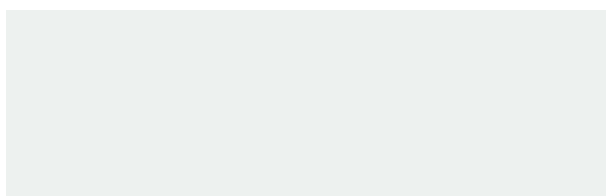
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Senior Reporter, TC+ |

Ryan Lawler was a technology writer for TC+ focused on the B2B fintech market. He most recently served as Head ...

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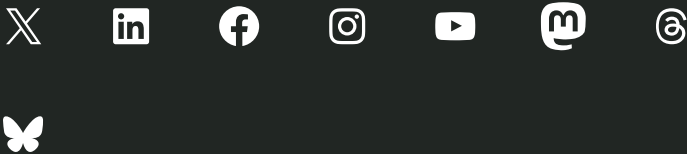
Mary Ann Azevedo

Sr. Reporter |

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